



FOREWORD

Plants are essential for life. They make our planet's atmosphere breathable, their decaying bodies create the soil under our feet, and they transform light energy into consumable nutrients that keep us alive. They also inspire artists; think of Georgia O'Keeffe's *Poppies*, Claude Monet's *Water Lilies*, and Vincent van Gogh's *Sunflowers*.

Trees, Leaves, Flowers & Seeds combines the art and science of plants, revealing complex botanical details in beautiful photographs and simple graphics. While previewing this book, I wondered where it was when I was a child interested in learning more about plants.

It reminded me why I began my career in horticulture. At its most basic level, horticulture is the science and art of growing plants.

This amalgamation of disciplines is what first attracted me to the profession and has held my interest for more than 40 years. This volume brought me back to Hort Studies 101, with each chapter examining different plants, their parts, and how they interact with the world around them. Thankfully, the photographs used reveal details—ranging from tangled roots to distinctive seed and flower shapes—that surpass the old transparency sheets used by my professors.

Similar to *Trees, Leaves, Flowers & Seeds*, Smithsonian Gardens combines art and science in its many diverse garden and landscape exhibits. While their beauty is often what initially attracts visitors, the science they embody showcases our living collections and provides

